22 July 2026

Editor
Marine Environmental Research

Re: Full-length Article submission, “Spatiotemporal associations between coastal birds and Pacific herring spawning in British Columbia”

Dear Editor,

Please consider this manuscript as a Full-length Article in *Marine Environmental Research*. We ask whether the short-lived Pacific herring spawn pulse produces a spatially local, temporally structured, and taxon-specific signature in coastal bird checklists. The study links effort-aware complete eBird checklists to event-level Fisheries and Oceans Canada spawn information and tests biologically motivated predictions using registered analyses.

The results provide a partial and qualified resource-pulse answer. The manuscript now foregrounds complete individual-species evidence: all 49 taxa that met frozen response-free support rules are displayed, rather than only taxa prioritized by the strength of their prior literature. Common shore and sea birds showed positive, negative, mixed, and region-dependent associations. Surf Scoter and Short-billed Gull were especially consistent across regions, while guild results provide a secondary mechanism-based synthesis. Event-window coefficients did not form one community-wide trajectory. Matched WCVI spatial and observer sensitivities preserved most directions, and response-blind shifted-exposure placebos were null after Benjamini-Hochberg adjustment.

The manuscript prominently reports a non-null prespecified Strait of Georgia specificity panel. That result constrains causal and simple ecological-specificity interpretations without erasing the checklist-conditional associations or directly testing conditional positive-count responses. The paper therefore presents the ecological signal, its taxonomic and regional heterogeneity, and the observation-process alternatives needed for a balanced interpretation.

The manuscript fits the journal's interest in biological interactions and quantitative monitoring of coastal systems. Relevant reviewer expertise includes coastal-bird and forage-fish ecology, community-science inference, mixed-effects models, spatial exposure linkage, falsification methods, and reproducible ecological analysis.

[AUTHOR TO CONFIRM BEFORE SUBMISSION: This work has not been published previously except as any disclosed preprint, is not under consideration elsewhere, and its submission and publication are approved by the author and responsible institution.]

[AUTHOR TO CONFIRM BEFORE SUBMISSION: Identify any preprint or closely related submitted/published work, or state “None.”]

Privacy-safe aggregate data, code, specifications, and provenance are available at https://github.com/JTDingwall/herring-x-ebird-version-2. Restricted eBird records and protected row-level derivatives cannot be redistributed; the manuscript explains the source-access route and reconstruction requirements. No production response model or protected sensitivity was rerun for manuscript preparation, no statistical estimate changed, and no frozen analysis artifact was altered.

Thank you for considering the manuscript.

Sincerely,

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[AUTHOR TO SUPPLY: full postal address and telephone number]